



(Clockwise from top left), CM Sarma at SP conference, at the conference with OCs, OCs listening to the CM, Sarma heading an 18-hour-long meeting with top police officials in Guwahati

THE NET WIDENS

Since May 2021, there has been a sharp rise in the number of cases registered and persons arrested under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act, 1985

	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022 (Up to March 6)
Case registered	367	455	826	980	2,271	522
Person Arrested	559	694	1226	1652	3851	901
Heroin	5.670 Kg	7.040 Kg	23.591 Kg	27.442 Kg	67.211505 Kg	19 Kg
Ganja	7,125.50 Kg	10,396.82 Kg	8,217.34 Kg	7,954.04 Kg	19,075.25 Kg	6,163.09 Kg
Opium	30.11 Kg	10.40 Kg	26.53 Kg	16.48 Kg	73.35 Kg	1.44 Kg
Cough Syrup	147891 Bottles	125301 Bottles	55418 Bottles	87472 Bottles	156697 Bottles	55560 Bottles
Psychotropic Substance (Tablets/Capsules)	168267	3081036	1537745	1277522	3201287	776533
Poppy Straw					3314 Kg	
Morphine			5.561 KG	23.571 Kg	4.7671 Kg	0.033 Kg
Fortwin/Zocin Injection			451	700		
Cocaine				1.34 Kg	0.29 Kg	0.02 Kg
Crystalline	Nil			5 Kg	3.38 Kg	
Cash Seized	Nil			Rs 78,27,930	Rs 24,055,148	Rs 2,307,937
Cannabis Plant	Nil	Nil	Nil	Nil	213.94 Kg	
Raw Opium Bud	Nil	Nil	Nil	Nil	Nil	10 Kg
Tramadol	Nil	Nil	Nil	Nil	Nil	0.56 kg
Cultivation Destroyed	Nil	4 Bigha, 12 Lessa		69 Bigha 1 Katha	30 Bigha (Opium cultivation) and 31 Bigha 3 Katha 12 Lessa (Cannabis cultivation)	648 Bigha (Opium Cultivation)

Since then, several such incidents of firing, while criminals tried to flee from custody, have been reported, causing uproar among a section of people. Many have blamed the police team of staging fake encounters. But this growing tendency among criminals to escape police net is the result of an unprecedented fear gripping them. This fear is the result of the striking improvement in policing and investigation. The police teams are building watertight cases against arrested criminals and filing strong charge sheets which diminishes their chances of getting bails. Consequently, they try to jump the legal process forcing the police to take drastic actions. "Thanks to the chief minister's regular attention to heinous crimes, the process of investigation and charge sheeting enhanced dramatically," says GP Singh. Compared to the first two months of 2021, number of crimes in Assam has dropped by 30 per cent this year.

While the chief minister has taken a no-holds-barred approach against crime and criminals, the highlight of this mission has been Assam government's fight against drugs.

The Comparative study published by the United Nation Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) shows that total drugs users in Assam are about 2.21 per cent of the total population or about 7,00,000 people. The northeast region accounts for 8 per cent of India's total geographical area, but 41 (or 15 per cent) of the country's 272 districts vulnerable to drug addiction are in this region. "We can say that the trade in illegal drugs in the state is worth nearly Rs 5,000 crore annually," says Dr Sarma.

At the root of the drug menace is the region's geographical proximity to Myanmar which, along with Lao PDR and Thailand, belongs to the Golden Triangle of drug trade. The triangle accounts for 65 per cent of world's opium poppy cultivation and 68 per cent of illicit opium production and refining. Northeast India shares a 1,643 km border with Myanmar, which is responsible for 95 per cent of the total opium production in the Golden Triangle and, according to the US Drug Enforcement Administration, 80 per cent of the heroin production in Southeast Asia and responsible for 60 per cent of the world's supply. As per International Narcotics Control Board and the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC), Myanmar is also one of Asia's main sources of illegal production of methamphetamine, or the "crazy drug" Yaba.

From Myanmar, narcotics substance reaches Assam through various routes originating mostly in the states of Nagaland, Manipur, and Mizoram. In fact, a drug nexus operating in Mizoram had a role in the territorial clash between the two neighbouring states in August 2021 as they wanted to divert Assam police's attention on the narcotics smuggling. Mizoram's strategic location, sharing 704 km border with Myanmar and Bangladesh—a destination country for drug trafficking—makes the state an easy transit route. A Mizoram Government Report says that nearly half a dozen syndicates are involved in heroin smuggling from Myanmar.

Between March 6, 2022, and May 10, 2021, the day Dr Sarma took charge, 4,117 persons have been arrested in 2,401 drug-related cases,